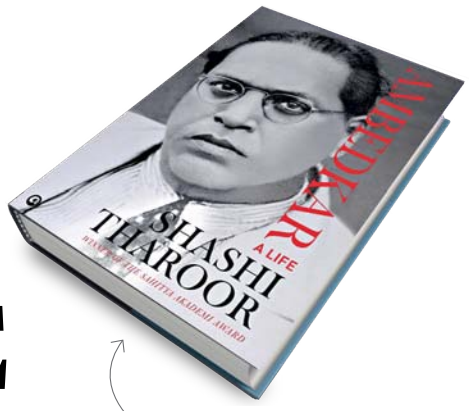
BOOKS

BABASAHEB IN WIDE ANGLE



AMBEDKAR: A LIFE
by Shashi Tharoor
ALEPH, NEW DELHI
₹599; 226 pages

By Rajmohan Gandhi

I would be surprised if any other modest-sized book offers as full a chronicle of Babasaheb's life as this one by Tharoor. Every significant episode from childhood humiliations in Maharashtra to his eve-of-death public renouncing of Hinduism and embrace of Buddhism is covered here. Including the Columbia PhD in 1927, the 1932 "Poona Pact" with Gandhi, Ambedkar's history-shaking 1936 text, *Annihilation of Caste*, the unexpected invitation in 1947 to lead the drafting of the Constitution, his command of the Constitution's passage, his abrupt 1951 resignation, and so much more. Given the author's flair, it is not surprising that this biography is readable. It is also courageous, with one chapter titled 'Ambedkar's Four Flaws'. In this brief review, it would be unfair to name the shortcomings that Tharoor dares to identify, and equally improper to comment on Tharoor's assessments.

But I must offer one criticism right way. It is something of which Tharoor is very conscious, for he attempts to answer it in his opening lines. Indirectly conceding that his book fails to present the unceasing drama of and in Ambedkar's life, Tharoor warns the reader that the story being told is of "the rise of a man of ideas", not "of a man of physical adventure". What? Must people chase dangerous summits, the ocean's depths, or stars in space in order to be able to arrest the human mind? Tharoor indeed zeroes in on Ambedkar's monumental feat, which was to get millions of Indians to reject the indignities to which the Indian air had long condemned them, and to get millions of other Indians to recognise the inhumanity to which they had shut their eyes. But if Ambedkar's thoughts were irresistible, so was his

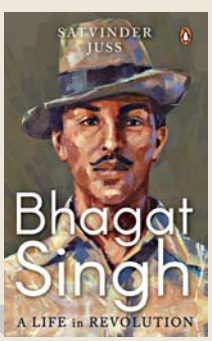


BANDEEP SINGH

This biography is not only readable, it's also courageous, with one chapter titled 'Ambedkar's Four Flaws'

THE LIFE AND TIMES

New political biographies



BHAGAT SINGH: A Life in Revolution
By Satvinder Juss
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA,
Pg **544,**
₹999

The short life of this nationalist martyr has cast a long shadow in the subcontinent. This substantial biography offers both historical context on the world from which Bhagat Singh emerged and analysis of the complexity of his legacy and the many claims to it across the political and geographic spectrum.

